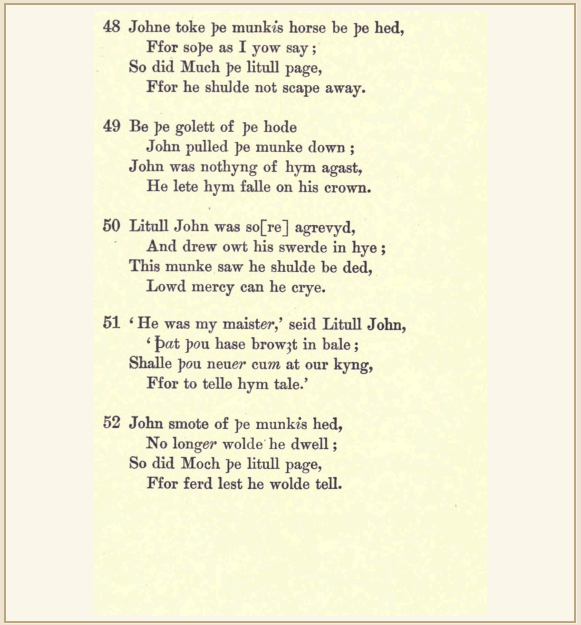


48 Johne toke þe munkis horse be þe hed,
Ffor soþe as I yow say;
So did Much þe litull page,
Ffor he shulde not scape away.

49 Be þe golett of þe hode
John pulled þe munke down;
John was nothyng of hym agast,
He lete hym falle on his crown.

50 Litull John was so[re] agrevyd,
And drew owt his swerde in hye;
This munke saw he shulde be ded,
Lowd mercy can he crye.

51 'He was my maister,' seid Litull John,
'Þat þou hase browȝt in bale;
Shalle þou neuer cum at our kyng,
Ffor to telle hym tale.'

52 John smote of þe munkis hed,
No longer wolde he dwell;
So did Moch þe litull page,
Ffor ferd lest he wolde tell.

Robin Hood and the Monk

About 1450 · Ballad, stanzas 48–52 · Original: Cambridge University Library MS Ff.5.48 · Text as printed by F. J. Child, 1888

The oldest surviving Robin Hood ballad, and an openly violent one: Little John beheads the monk who betrayed Robin, and Much kills the monk's young page 'for ferd lest he wolde tell'.

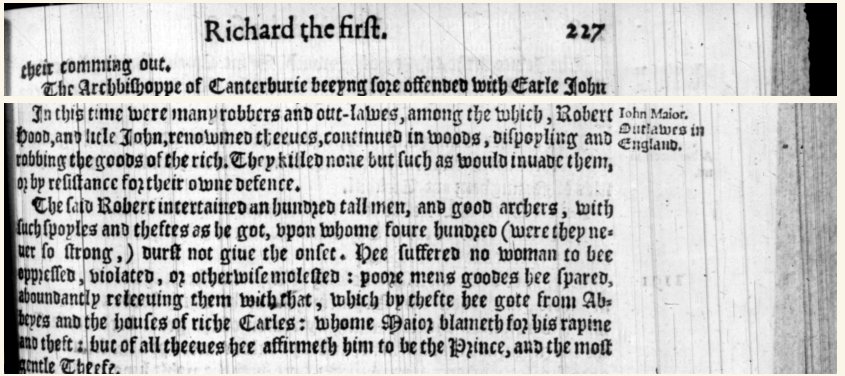


Lythe and listin gentilmen þat be of frebore blode I shall you tel of a gode yeman his name was Robyn hode Robyn was a proude out law as he was one was neuer non founde Ro byn stode in barnesdale stondyng hym to a tre and bi hym stode litell Johan a gode yeman was he and also dyd good Scarlok and mych þ millers sun The re was none such of his bodi but it was wor thy a grome. Than bespake lytell Johan all un to Robyn hode Maister and ye wolde dyne betyme it wolde do you moche gode. Than be spake hym gode Robyn to dyne haue I noo lust till that I haue slayne some bolde baron or som unkouth gest that may pay for his best, or som knyght or

A Gest of Robyn Hode

Printed in Edinburgh by Chepman & Myllar, c.1508 · Opening page · Reproduction; original in the National Library of Scotland

The longest early ballad: 'Lythe and listin, gentilmen…'. Robin helps a poor knight with a loan, but never robs the rich to give to the poor.



Richard the first. 227

their comming out.
The Archbishoppe of Canterburie beeyng sore offended with Earle John

In this time were many robbers and out-lawes, among the which, Robert Hood, and lytle John, renowmed theeues, continued in woods, dispoyling and robbing the goods of the rich. They killed none but such as would inuade them, or by resistance for their owne defence. John Maior. Outlawes in England.

The said Robert intertained an hundred tall men, and good archers, with such spoyles and thefts as he got, vpon whome foure hundred (were they neuer so strong,) durst not giue the onset. Hee suffered no woman to bee oppressed, violated, or otherwise molested: poore mens goodes hee spared, aboundantly releeuing them with that, which by theft hee gote from Abbeyes and the houses of riche Carles: whome Maior blameth for his rapine and theft: but of all theeues hee affirmeth him to be the Prince, and the most gentle Theefe.

John Stow, *The Annales of England*

London, 1592 · Page 227 · Reproduction from the Early English Books scan

'…poore mens goodes hee spared, aboundantly releeuing them with that, which by thefte hee gote from Abbeyes and the houses of riche Carles.' The best-known part of the story is the latest addition.